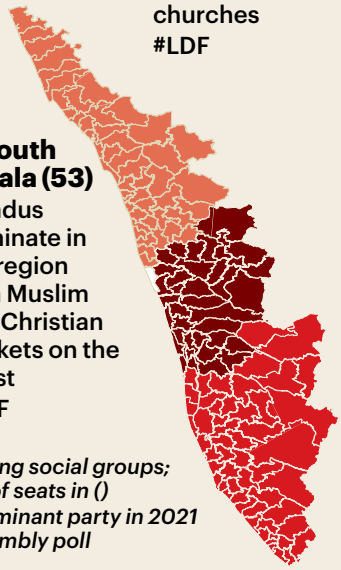


THE BATTLE ZONES

North Kerala (32)
*Muslims and Hindus
#LDF

Central Kerala (45)
*Christians, Muslims and Pentecostal churches
#LDF



South Kerala (53)
*Hindus dominate in the region with Muslim and Christian pockets on the coast
#LDF

**Swing social groups; no. of seats in ()*
#Dominant party in 2021 assembly poll

of the past 10 years. A case in point is the Rs 100 crore spent on the fourth anniversary celebration of Pinarayi 2.0. Congress leader and former Wayanad MP Rahul Gandhi upped the tempo at a rally on March 29 in Pathanamthitta, home to the famous Sabarimala shrine dedicated to Lord Ayyappa. To the question, '*Swarnam kattathu arappa* (Who stole the [Lord's] gold)?', the crowds roared back, '*Saghaakkalaane Ayyappa* (The comrades did it, Ayyappa)', reviving the CPI(M)'s nightmare of the missing gold from the hill temple.

Leader of the Opposition V.D. Satheesan is confident the UDF will win 110 seats. "The people have had enough of this government; that was evident after the local body polls last year. They will vote us to power to end the misrule in the state," he says. The Congress campaign also got fresh wind in its sails when the Modi government introduced the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill (FCRA) Bill on March 25, giving it a chance to deflate the BJP's Christian outreach in Kerala. Though postponed for now, the bill sought to regulate the acceptance and utilisation of foreign contribution by individuals, associations and companies, sparking protests from Kerala churches that feared its provisions would affect their functioning. "The timing of the FCRA Bill was a blessing in disguise for the Congress in Kerala," says poll analyst Sunnykutty Abraham. "The church and the community were worried about the amendment. They will rally behind the Congress and the UDF now. It will help the UDF sweep the polls in south and central Kerala."

To win, though, the Congress-led UDF will have to rein in the competing ambitions of its leaders. There was talk of a three-way tussle between Satheesan, Delhi-based MP and general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal and campaign committee chairman Ramesh Chennithala over candidate selection, but Satheesan dismisses it. The UDF will also have to get its electoral math right. The seat-sharing gives the Congress 90-plus seats, but the key question is whether allies IUML (in Malabar) and the KC(J), which has sway over the Christian electorate in central Kerala, will be able to transfer their votes to the party. Opinion polls give UDF the advantage in northern districts like Malappuram and Wayanad, where IUML and Congress networks are entrenched. But central Kerala, including the districts of Kottayam, Ernakulam, Idukki and Thrissur, is where they will win or lose the battle. The region accounts for 40-plus seats, and the Congress must turn around its poor 2021 performance here to win.

Queering the pitch for both the LDF and UDF this election could be the BJP-led NDA, which has upped both its ambition and campaign in Kerala. Not only did the party announce its candidates' list early, it also amplified its electoral intent with the slogan '*Maaraathathu Ini Maarum* (What did not will now change)'. Winning back Nemom, a Hindu-majority constituency with a strong RSS presence that gave the party its first and only MLA in 2016, is central to the party's ambitions here. The other 'winnable' seats include Manjeshwar in the north, Palakkad, and select constituencies in Thrissur and Thiruvananthapuram. The party is relying heavily on leaders like new state president Rajeev Chandrasekhar, and veteran leaders like K. Surendran and Union minister V. Muraleedharan. The strategy is to consolidate the Hindu vote and earn returns from the Christian outreach.

A Tight Race

Political analyst A. Jayashankar, who has been following state elections for over three decades now, feels the balance is still in favour of the LDF. "There is a negative wave against Pinarayi, but the Left legislators largely remain popular in their respective constituencies. If the LDF wins, it will be south-central Kerala that saves them—Thiruvananthapuram, Kollam, Alappuzha, Pathanamthitta, Kottayam and Idukki," he says. These districts account for 53 seats, and the LDF won 44 of them in 2021.

Opinion polls give the UDF advantage in northern districts like Malappuram and Wayanad, where Congress and IUML networks are strong. But central Kerala is where they will win or lose the battle

The Congress's Chennithala, who is contesting from Haripad, does not see that happening. "People are fed up with the corrupt LDF regime," he says. "Just look at the number of CPI(M) rebels supporting the Congress and fighting against their party candidates. Even CPI(M) stronghold Kannur will vote for the UDF this time." In the midst of all this, two factors could send the calculations of all political parties awry: new voters and women. The state has enrolled 466,000 new voters under 20, and some 4.77 million women voters are under 40. How they vote on April 9 could provide some dramatic twists to the Kerala story. ■